LIMO

An abstract duel of black and white · Game rules

Game by **Oleg Kovalskyi**

2 players
age **8+**
3–10 min
board **7 × 7**

Each player's goal is to place as many cells of their own color on the board as possible while keeping them from building up into **formations**, and at the same time to build up as many **formations** as possible out of the opponent's cells.

Exactly which formations matter, and how they decide the winner, depends on the chosen mode.

□ first player's cell (white) ■ second player's cell (black)

01 COMPONENTS

A **7×7 board** — 49 cells. A **shared bank of 17 pieces** — one bank for both players. Each piece is a shape made of a few elementary cells: some white, some black. Pieces differ only in shape and size — from 1 to 6 cells.

A piece may be rotated and may be used on either of its two physical sides. The reverse side has the same shape but the opposite colors: every white cell becomes black, and every black cell becomes white. Below is the whole bank, grouped by size and shown with the side more favorable to the white player.

MONO
1 cell · 1 piece



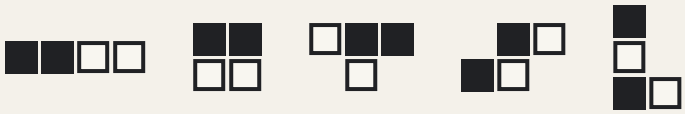
DOMINO
2 cells · 2 pieces



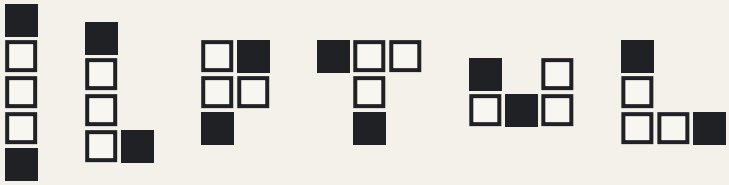
TROMINO
3 cells · 2 pieces



TETROMINO
4 cells · 5 pieces



PENTOMINO
5 cells · 6 pieces



HEXOMINO
6 cells · 1 piece



02 THE GOAL

The first player plays white and counts white cells as their own. The second player plays black and counts black cells as their own.

LIMO has three modes, so the exact winning condition depends on the mode. In **Basic**, the main goal is to avoid making a line of 6 cells of your own color; if no such line appears, the player with more cells of their own color wins. In **Extended** and **Extreme**, the game continues until no move is possible, and the winner is the player with more points.

THE REVERSIVE TWIST

A **formation** is a group of same-color cells that has come together into a set shape: a straight line of 6 cells, or a solid 2×2 square. The core rule is reversive: a formation made of **your color** always plays against you, while a formation made of the **opponent's color** plays for you. So it pays to scatter your own color and to herd the opponent's color into formations.

03 SETUP

- An empty 7×7 board in front of the players.
- A shared bank of 17 pieces — available to both.
- Decide who plays white: that player goes first.
- Choose the mode before the first move: Basic, Extended, or Extreme.

04 THE TURN

Players take turns. On your turn:

1. Pick any piece from the shared bank.
2. Rotate it and, if needed, turn it over to use the reverse side with the opposite colors.
3. Place it on the board: every cell of the piece must land on empty cells within the board. You may not overlap occupied cells.

A placed piece **leaves the bank for good** — for both players. Then the opponent moves.

Moving is mandatory. If there is at least one legal spot for any piece, the player must make a move — no matter which side of the piece it uses or how unfavorable the move is. You may only pass when there is truly nowhere left to place anything. When neither player can move, the game ends and scoring begins, unless the Basic mode has already ended by a line of 6.

05 THREE MODES

LIMO is played with one of three rule sets. Agree on the mode before the game begins.

MODE 1 BASIC

The shortest and sharpest version — a single mistake can decide everything.

Players take turns placing one piece each, either side up.

- The moment a legal placement makes a straight line of **6 consecutive cells of one color** appear on the board, the player whose color it is **loses instantly**. Lines count horizontally, vertically, and diagonally.
- If the same move creates a line of 6 for both colors at the same time, the game is a **draw**.
- If no such line ever forms and the moves run out, the winner is the player with **more cells of their own color** on the board. If the players have the same number of own-color cells, the game is a **draw**.

Keep your color thin: one careless line of six is enough to hand over the game.

MODE 2

EXTENDED

Play to the end and count points. A line does not end the game — it is worth points.

Players take turns placing one piece each, either side up.

COLOR MAJORITY	At the end of the game, compare how many cells of each player's own color are on the board. The player with more own-color cells scores the difference. If both players have the same number, neither player scores majority points.
OPPONENT'S LINES	Each line of 6 consecutive cells of the opponent's color scores **+1**. Count every separate window of 6: a continuous row, column, or diagonal of 7 cells contains 2 such lines, so it scores 2 points.
OPPONENT'S SQUARES	Each new 2×2 square of the opponent's color is worth 1 more point than the previous one: 1st square = 1 point, 2nd = 2 points, 3rd = 3 points, and so on. Overlapping 2×2 squares count separately.

The winner is the player with **more points**. If the players have the same number of points, the game is a **draw**.

MODE 3

EXTREME

Play to the end and count points — but the opponent's lines are worth three times as much, and the mono piece is banned until the very finish.

Players take turns placing one piece each, either side up.

COLOR MAJORITY	At the end of the game, compare how many cells of each player's own color are on the board. The player with more own-color cells scores the difference. If both players have the same number, neither player scores majority points.
OPPONENT'S LINES	Each line of 6 consecutive cells of the opponent's color scores **+3**. Count every separate window of 6: a continuous row, column, or diagonal of 7 cells contains 2 such lines, so it scores 6 points.
OPPONENT'S SQUARES	Each new 2×2 square of the opponent's color is worth 1 more point than the previous one: 1st square = 1 point, 2nd = 2 points, 3rd = 3 points, and so on. Overlapping 2×2 squares count separately.

Special rule. The mono piece (1 cell) may be placed only last — when no other piece fits anywhere in any orientation.

The winner is the player with **more points**. If the players have the same number of points, the game is a **draw**.

06

READING THE FORMATIONS

The examples below are shown in black: the opponent's color, the one you score points for. For your own color, the same formations play against you.

Count every separate group of 6 consecutive same-color cells in a straight line: horizontally, vertically, or diagonally. Count every separate 2×2 square of same-color cells. Overlapping formations still count as separate formations.

LINE OF 6



6 cells in a row — along a row, column, or diagonal. In Basic it is an instant loss for the owner of the color; in the scoring modes it is +1 in Extended or +3 in Extreme.

ROW OF 7 = TWO LINES



A solid row of **7 cells** contains two different windows of 6 cells: cells 1–6 and cells 2–7. So it counts as **2 lines**. The same rule applies to columns and diagonals.

2×2 SQUARE



Four cells of one color in a 2×2 block. Each new square is worth 1 more point than the previous one: first = 1, second = 2, third = 3, and so on.

2×3 BLOCK = TWO SQUARES



A 2×3 block contains two overlapping 2×2 squares. They count separately. The first square scores 1 point and the second scores 2 points, for **1 + 2 = 3 points**.

07 A FEW TIPS

- **Scatter** your own color across the board; avoid three or four of your cells in a row — that is the seed of an opponent's line against you.
- When choosing how to place a piece, look not only at where your color lands, but also at where the **opponent's** cells end up — those are what earn you points.
- In the Basic game, watch the **diagonals**: they are easy to overlook, and a line of six on a diagonal loses just as instantly.
- In Extreme, try to make the **last move yours**: since moving is mandatory, toward the end your opponent is forced to place pieces that only spoil their position. Save the mono piece — it may be played only at the very end.